

ENGLISH: 095

LEARNING RESOURCES



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English 095 Learning Resources

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Always Be Prepared

1.1: Preparing to Learn

1.2: Organizing Your Time

1.3: Preparing to Read

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1.1: Preparing to Learn

Know Yourself: What is your Learning Style?

“*Reading is a complex task. No single part of the brain can do all the work,*” (Q. HE)

Believe it or not, we don’t all learn the same way. In fact, reading is a new enough behavior for humans that there is no wiring in our brains specifically for reading. Each and every one of us make those neural connections differently.

This is a good reason to pay attention to your learning preferences. Being aware of your own learning preferences can help you to use strategies and tools for learning that will support what you naturally do. Of course, it’s still important to use strategies that “stretch” your brain a bit too – you never know when you might need those other strategies!

Note

Throughout this text, you will find both graded activities (Learning Activities, which will have corresponding submission spaces on BlackBoard) and optional exercises which are unscored. You should skim readings and activities at the beginning of the period they are assigned to determine how much time they might take you, and to manage your schedule accordingly. If an activity is labeled as an "Optional Exercise," you only need to complete it if you have the time and interest. "Learning Activities," on the other hand, cannot be made up if the due date passes and you did not submit the work.

Optional Exercise: Learning Style

This [link](#) contains a short quiz that shows you how you learn best, which you might find helpful if you have never before considered what ways you best absorb information. You may also enjoy several other questionnaires under the self-assessment tab to the left on the page you will land.

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1.2: Organizing Your Time

Learning Objectives

- Understand the basic principles of time management and planning.
- Practice time management strategies to help ensure your academic success.

When you know what you want to do, why not just sit down and get it done? The millions of people who complain frequently about “not having enough time” would love it if it were that simple!

Time and Your Personality

People’s attitudes toward time vary widely. One person seems to be always rushing around but actually gets less done than another person who seems unconcerned about time and calmly goes about the day. Since there are so many different “time personalities,” it’s important to realize how you approach time. Start by trying to figure out how you spend your time during a typical week with this exercise.

? Optional Exercise

Where Does the Time Go?

See if you can account for a week’s worth of time by creating this chart and filling in the columns to estimate how many hours you spend in a week doing each activity. (You can estimate how many hours for one day and multiply by seven for daily activities.)

Category of Activity	# of hours per week
Sleeping	
Eating (including preparing food)	
Personal hygiene (i.e., bathing, etc.)	
Working (employment)	
Volunteer service or internship	
Chores, cleaning, errands, shopping, etc.	
Attending class	
Studying, reading, and researching (outside of class)	
Transportation to work or school	
Getting to classes (walking, biking, etc.)	
Organized group activities (clubs, church services, etc.)	
Time with friends (include television, video games, etc.)	
Attending events (movies, parties, etc.)	
Time alone (include television, video games, surfing the Web, etc.)	
Exercise or sports activities	
Reading for fun or other interests done alone	
Talking on phone, e-mail, Facebook, etc.	

Now total your estimated hours. Is your number larger or smaller than 168, the total number of hours in a week? If your estimate is higher, go back through your list and adjust numbers to be more realistic. But if your total is fewer than 168, don't just add more time in categories. Instead, ponder this: *Where does the time go?* We'll come back to this question.

Plan your tasks according to time of day.

When you need to concentrate, such as when writing a class paper, are you more alert and focused in the morning, afternoon, or evening? Do you concentrate best when you look forward to a relaxing activity later on, or do you study better when you've finished all other activities? Understanding this will help you better plan your study periods.

Estimate your time realistically.

Think about your time analysis in this exercise. People who estimate too high often feel they don't have enough time. They may have time anxiety and often feel frustrated. People at the other extreme, who often can't account for how they use all their time, may have a more relaxed attitude. They may not actually have any more free time, but they may be wasting more time than they want to admit with less important things.

Be prepared for schedule changes.

People also differ in how they respond to schedule changes. Some go with the flow and accept changes easily, while others function well only when following a planned schedule and may become upset if that schedule changes. If you do not react well to an unexpected disruption in your schedule, plan extra time for catching up if something throws you off. This is all part of understanding your time personality.

Time Management

- Time management for successful university studying involves these factors:
- Determining how much time you need to spend studying
- Knowing how much time you actually have for studying and increasing that time if needed
- Being aware of the times of day you are at your best and most focused
- Using effective long- and short-term study strategies
- Scheduling study activities in realistic segments
- Using a system to plan ahead and set priorities
- Staying motivated to follow your plan and avoid procrastination

For every hour in the classroom, university students should spend, on average, about two hours on that class, counting reading, studying, writing papers, and so on. If you're a full-time student with fifteen hours a week in class, then you need another thirty hours for the rest of your academic work. That forty-five hours is about the same as a typical full-time job. If you work part-time, time management skills are even more essential. These skills are still more important for part-time university students who work full time and commute or have a family. To succeed in university studies, virtually everyone has to develop effective strategies for dealing with time.

Look back at the number of hours you wrote in *Where Does the Time Go* for a week of studying. Do you have two hours of study time for every hour in class? Many students begin college not knowing this much time is needed, so don't be surprised if you underestimated this number of hours. Remember this is just an average amount of study time—you may need more or less for your own courses.

Set and Commit to Your Schedule

Put your schedule on a calendar and post it where you and other people in your life can easily refer to it.

Once you've allotted time for study, stick to it. If you occasionally have more time than you need for your assignments, try working ahead. Get a jump on a paper, project, or on the next chapter of the textbook – you'll thank yourself later. Sure, you may need to adjust for the surprises, both good and bad, that pop up in all of our lives, but if you've made a place in your schedule for your school work, you won't have to face the stress of rearranging your activities at the last minute.

Making your schedule consistent and available to the important people in your life (including you) will help you to develop study habits that will make your investment in college a successful one.

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1.3: Preparing to Read

Why Am I reading this?

You may be thinking to yourself, “Prepare to read? Don’t I just pick the text up and read it?” The answer to this is yes and no. It depends on your purpose for reading.

Think About: All the Things I Read

You read all the time, and you have your own reasons for doing so. Brainstorm a list of all the different types of texts you read throughout the day. Think about walking through the halls, driving down the road, sitting in a waiting room, etc. What do you read in these and other locations? For what purposes do you read? All of these different materials we consume change the ways in which we read and affect the ways we comprehend the world.

Think about the various materials you read on a daily or weekly basis. For the kinds of texts you interact with most frequently, in what *ways do you approach reading*, *what purposes* do you have for reading, and how do you ensure that *you understand* what you read?

How to Read Academic Texts

As you may have noticed, different purposes for reading affect the way you choose to read a given text. Academic texts are typically selected as a source of information or to provide a different perspective. You will be expected to learn from, explain, or use this kind of textual material to support your stance on a topic.

The kind of **passive reading** you may do when you read a light novel will not be helpful for you with academic texts. For this kind of learning you will need to use **active reading** strategies.

Active Reading Strategies

Have you ever read something and then realized you don’t remember a word of what you just read? That is because you were passively reading – you were not engaged in the text. The following suggestions will help you to stay engaged in what you read so that you can learn the information and use it later.

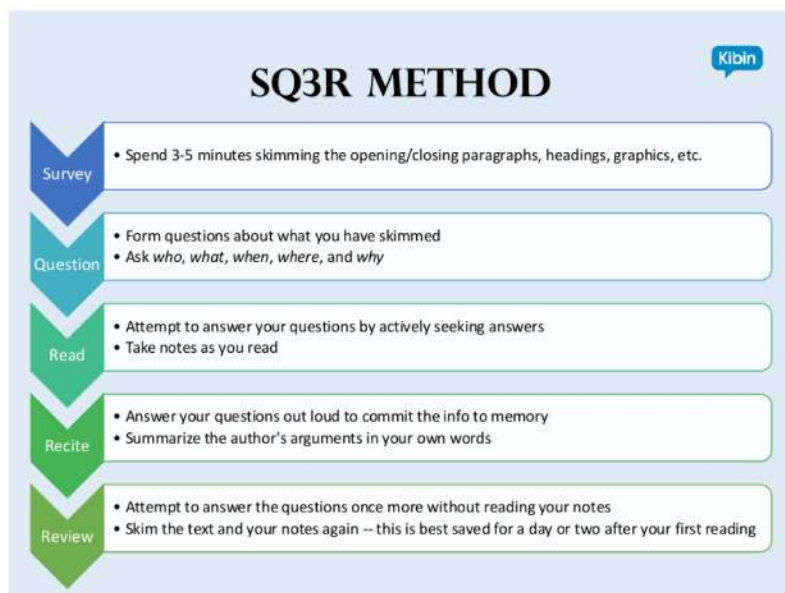
Successful students approach reading with a strategy that helps them get the most out of their reading. These students read actively. They look for the main idea of the material, its themes, and for words they do not understand.

The opposite of reading actively is reading passively. Passive readers simply skip over things they do not understand and have difficulty understanding the material as a result.

In this course, we are going to practice active reading. You will find that active reading is often more enjoyable, lets you understand more of what you have read, and leads to higher test scores.

SQ3R

Active reading strategies can significantly increase learning new information. SQ3R is one of the most popular active reading strategies designed to help retain information into long term memory. SQ3R is a five-step process.



The five steps involved in the SQ3R include:

Step 1. Survey – What can I learn from the text?

Pre-reading Strategy – When you read an academic text, it is well worth your time to skim/scan the reading first. Think out loud the first few times you do this. Look for the title, headings/subheadings, bold words, graphics, and other features of the text that stand out to you, and make notes about these on the reading or in your notebook:

- Skim the table of contents and write down three to five main ideas that will be presented in the text.
- Write down important names, headings, and subheadings.
- Look at the captions under images, tables, diagrams and maps; make notes of where this information exists.
- Pay particular attention to the introductory and final paragraphs, which often contain a summary of the text. Write down a few key ideas from both paragraphs.

Step 2. Question – What do I hope to learn from the text?

Before reading a section, formulate your own questions and do the following:

- Rephrase headings and titles into questions you hope to answer.
- Look whether the author has formulated questions at the beginning or end of the section. Rewrite these questions in your own words.
- Predict what you think the section will be about. Turn this prediction into a question you think the section will answer.
- Recall what you already know about the topic and what you still want to learn about it.
- Write out all the questions for consideration. You'll find answers to the questions in the next step.

Step 3. Read & Annotate! – Look for answers to your questions.

- Always read with a pen and highlighter in hand (or keyboard). See the handout on “Annotating a Text” before reading your assigned text.
- Read captions under images and diagrams. Pay attention to highlighted information.
- Be open-minded – pay attention to new ideas and differing opinions.
- Reduce your speed and/or stop and reread difficult and unclear parts.
- Look for answers to the questions you first raised during the questioning that took place in step 2. Write out the answers to these questions.
- Answer questions at the beginning or end of the chapters.
- Note all the underlined, italicized, bold printed words or phrases.
- Read only a section at a time and *recite* after each section.

Step 4. Recite – Consider what you want to remember from the information obtained.

- Think about what you've read and summarize the main ideas expressed in the section.
- If you realize there is something you have not fully understood, reread that section.
- Take notes, expressing ideas in your own words.
- Reciting: The more senses you use the more likely you are to remember what you read. To triple strength learning apply: seeing, saying and hearing. To quadruple strength learning apply: seeing, saying, hearing, and writing!

Step 5. Recall – Reread your notes and link the information with your own experience.

- After reading the whole text, reread your own notes and pay attention to the main ideas and connections between the ideas.
- Link what you have learned with your own experience and other sources of information.
- This step is an ongoing process.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Building Vocabulary and Reading Critically

2.1: Words Influence Literacy

2.1.1: Critical Reading

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2.1: Words Influence Literacy

Vocabulary Strategies: Preparing to Comprehend What You Read

Why do instructors insist on teaching you vocabulary? It turns out your ability to understand key vocabulary in a reading directly affects your ability to comprehend the overall text.

This section will focus upon strategies for **comprehending** the meanings of **key words** in a text without using the dictionary unless absolutely necessary.

The Big Picture: Context Clues

Context refers to surrounding time, place, and circumstances of a situation. We make assumptions about what happens in the world around us by observing context. Consider the following narrative in which a student observes other students in the library:

Context Clues are specific to reading – they are clues found in the surrounding text that help the reader to define a **key word**.

Why use context clues? This is a very effective and efficient way to get the general meaning of a word that does not interrupt the flow of your reading. You can find the meaning of a word by reading the sentence and considering the words around it

Kinds of Context clues

? Watch to Learn

Watch the video, [Word Attack! Using Context Clues to Become a Word Ninja](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pbqJ...ature=youtu.be) (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pbqJ...ature=youtu.be>). Notetaking is recommended. After watching the video, you should be able to understand how the following types of context clues work to equip you to come up with a reasonable guess when it comes to the meaning of an unknown word:

1. Definition Clues
2. Synonym/Example Clues
3. Antonym/Contrast Clues
4. GIST

Bits & Pieces: Word Parts

Your “Plan B” for determining the meaning of a key word should be using **word parts**, or morphemes. Word parts are exactly what it sounds like – the reader breaks the word into parts and derives meaning by using what is known about the part’s meaning. It doesn’t necessarily interrupt the flow of reading, but, depending upon the reader, it may briefly.

There are Three Categories of Morphemes

Root Words

- Roots are the basis of complex words.
- Prefixes or suffixes may be added to them to modify the meaning.

Prefixes

- Prefixes are **added to the beginning** of a word to modify the meaning.

Suffixes

- Suffixes are **added to the end** of a word to modify the meaning.

Let’s try this out. Here is how word parts can be used to define the word “irreversible.”

Break the word into syllables: ir-re-vers-i-ble

At this point, determining which syllables make up which parts can be kind of like solving a mystery. The more word parts you are familiar with, the easier this becomes.

- **Prefix:** re- (meaning: *turning*)
 - “reverse” means to turn again, to go back
- **Suffix:** ible (meaning: *able to*)
 - “reversible” means able to turn again, or able to turn back
- **Prefix:** ir (meaning: *not*)
 - “irreversible” means not able to turn again, or not able to turn back

Why Would I Do This?

Knowing word parts is efficient. It turns out that when a reader knows a set of 20 prefixes and 14 roots, and knows how to use them, they will unlock the meaning of over 100,000 words. (Imagine adding suffixes!) Would you rather learn 20 prefixes and 14 roots, or would you rather learn the individual definitions of over 100,000 words?

If you are entering a vocational program where there is a large amount of vocabulary, such as medical fields, this is THE way to learn key vocabulary, because discipline-specific vocabulary is often based upon specific, regularly occurring word parts.

Morphemes develop over time, so knowing the etymology, or history, of a morpheme adds to your understanding of them and their many variations.

Tips for Working With Morphemes

- In *most* cases, a word is built on at least one root.
- Words *can* have more than one prefix, root, or suffix.
- Words *do not always* have both a prefix and a suffix
- Roots *may* change in spelling as they are combined with suffixes (arid arable)
- *Sometimes* you may identify a group of letters as a prefix or root, but find that it does not carry the meaning of the prefix or root.
- The link below contains many common morphemes. You aren't expected to memorize them all, but the more you begin to learn as you read more widely, the easier it will be to utilize morphemes to take educated guesses when you encounter unfamiliar words.

Common Morphemes--See this link!

When to use the Dictionary

Stopping to look up unknown words *while* you are reading is highly disruptive to the flow of reading. It effectively keeps you from understanding the broader message of a text. For that reason, we try to determine meanings of key words *AS* we read, perhaps marking words to look up later. Then return to the reading later to try out your understanding. Using the dictionary to understand key terms should be your *LAST* option.

That being said, there are many good reasons to use a dictionary. Use a dictionary to:

- Look up key words **before or after** reading a text.
- Learn how to pronounce a word correctly.
- Find out the origins or history of a word.
- Determine how to correctly break the word into syllables.

Dictionaries have changed considerably over the years, making them much easier to use. You can certainly use a printed book dictionary, or an online dictionary, which are often free, and typically provide audio so you can learn to how to pronounce an unknown word.

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2.1.1: Critical Reading

Reading for Understanding

Reading is a much harder skill to master than we think, and many instructors take this for granted when assigning academic material. We forget how hard it is to read and actually understand information that might be completely new to us.

Read, Re-read, Read Again

Reading critically takes skill and time. In order to really grasp hard material, it's recommended that you read it at least three times:

1. **Read for an Overview** - Read quickly, to get a general picture of the writer's purpose, methods, and conclusions. Authors do not always explicitly spell everything out for you --sometimes you must use inferences to figure out what the information is about.
2. **Read for Understanding** - Once you have a general idea, read a second time more carefully to gain a critical, thoughtful understanding of the key points. Think about what the author is presenting - if the author is writing to persuade, do they provide evidence and do you find the arguments convincing? (Use some of your evaluation skills here.)
3. **Read for Note Taking and Summary** - As you read a third time, begin to take brief notes about arguments, evidence, conclusions, or questions you still have.

Identifying Key Points and Arguments

Step one is relatively easy - this is how we read most everything. We skim through an article or online post to get the general meaning and an overview. Steps two and three become more difficult. When looking for key points and arguments, you are trying to determine how (or even if) you will use the source for your own research.

There are some places that commonly contain this type of information so these sections might be good places to start.

Abstract

If it's an academic journal article, it often includes an abstract. This is a one to two paragraph summary of the article that might include a research question, information on research subjects, and a very quick summary of findings. It is an excellent place to look to determine whether the research article is going to help you further your arguments.

Introduction

The purpose of the introduction to any piece that has one is to give information about what the reader can expect from the source as a whole. There are different types of introductions, including forewords and prefaces that may be written by the author of the book or by someone else with knowledge of the subject. Introductory sections can include background information on why the topic was chosen, background on the author's interest in the topic, context pertaining to why the topic is important, or the lens through which the topic will be explored. Knowing this information before diving in to the body of the work will help you understand the author's approach to the topic and how it might relate to the approach you are taking in your own research.

Table of Contents

Most of the time, if your source is a book or an entire website, it will be divided into sections that each cover a particular aspect of the overall topic. It may be necessary to read through all of these sections in order to get a "big picture" understanding of the information being discussed or it may be better to concentrate only on the areas that relate most closely to your own research. Looking over the table of contents or menu will help you decide whether you need the whole source or only pieces of it.

List of References

If the source you're using is research-based, it should have a list of references that usually appears at the end of the document. Reviewing these references will give you a better idea of the kind of work the author put into their own research. Did they put as much work into evaluating their sources as you are? Can you tell from the citations if the sources used were credible? When were they published? Do they represent a fair balance of perspectives or do they all support a limited point of view? What information does the author use from these sources and in what way does he or she use that information? Use your own research skills to spy on the research habits of others to help you evaluate the source.

Taking Notes about a Text

Note taking is sometimes referred to as annotating. Annotating simply means to take notes about the text you are reading. Some people hand-write directly on the document, some people hand-write separate notes on another piece of paper or in a notebook, and some people type up notes - you should do what feels best to you. There is research that shows that hand-writing notes with a good old fashioned paper and pen will help you retain more information than note taking on a computer ([Goodwin, 2018](#)).

Strategies for Connecting Reading and Writing

If you want to become a critical reader, you need to get into a habit of writing as you read. You also need to understand that complex texts cannot be read just once. Instead, they require multiple readings, the first of which may be a more general one during which you get acquainted with the ideas presented in the text, its structure and style. During the second and any subsequent readings, however, you will need to write, and write a lot. The following are some critical reading and writing techniques which active readers employ as they work to create meanings from texts they read.

- **Underline interesting and important places in the text:** Underline words, sentences, and passages that stand out, for whatever reason. Underline the key arguments that you believe the author of the text is making as well as any evidence, examples, and stories that seem interesting or important. Don't be afraid to "get it wrong." There is no right or wrong here. The places in the text that you underline may be the same or different from those noticed by your classmates, and this difference of interpretation is the essence of critical reading.
- **Take notes:** Take notes on the margins. If you do not want to write on your book or journal, attach post-it notes with your comments to the text. Do not be afraid to write too much. This is the stage of the reading process during which you are actively making meaning. Writing about what you read is the best way to make sense of it, especially if the text is difficult. Do not be afraid to write too much. This is the stage of the reading process during which you are actively making meaning. Writing about what you read will help you not only to remember the argument which the author of the text is trying to advance (less important for critical reading), but to create your own interpretations of the text you are reading (more important).
- **Keep a double entry journal:** Many writers like double-entry journals because they allow us to make that leap from summary of a source to interpretation and persuasion. To start a double-entry journal, divide a page into two columns. As you read, in the left column, record interesting and important words, sentences, quotations, and passages from the text. In the right column, write your reaction and responses to them. Be as formal or informal as you want. Record words, passages, and ideas from the text that you find interesting, useful for your paper or in any way striking or unusual.

In this video, the instructor is addressing an English class as she explains how to annotate a text. Many of the tips and suggestions she gives can apply to any type of critical reading for research. Take note of the suggestions she offers when annotating (underlining, highlighting, making notes in the margins). You'll be asked to annotate a source this week so you should decide what methods are most effective for you.

Click to access the [link](#) to open the video in a new tab.

Guiding Questions

As you take notes - you should be having a conversation with the text - this is called "talking to the text" and it will help you better understand what you're reading.

Reading critically means you are analyzing the logic of the article and/or chapter or section of a book. Here are some questions or prompts you can use to analyze logic while talking to the text:

1. What is the main purpose of this article or chapter/section?
2. What are the key questions the author is addressing?
3. What is the most important information in this article or chapter/section and how does this fit with what I already know about this subject?



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3: Identifying Thesis Statements

Learning Objectives

- Identify explicit thesis statements in texts
- Identify implicit thesis statements in texts
- Identify strategies for using thesis statements to predict content of texts

Being able to identify the purpose and thesis of a text, as you're reading it, takes practice. This section will offer you that practice.

One fun strategy for developing a deeper understanding the material you're reading is to make a visual "map" of the ideas. Mind maps, whether hand-drawn or done through computer programs, can be fun to make, and help put all the ideas of an essay you're reading in one easy-to-read format.

Your understanding of what the "central" element of the mind map is might change as you read and re-read. Developing the central idea of your mind map is a great way to help you determine the reading's thesis.

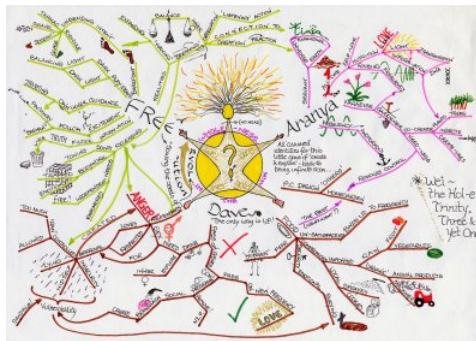


Figure 3.1 - Hand-drawn Mind Map

Locating Explicit and Implicit Thesis Statements

In academic writing, the thesis is often **explicit**: it is included as a sentence as part of the text. It might be near the beginning of the work, but not always—some types of academic writing leave the thesis until the conclusion.

Journalism and reporting also rely on explicit thesis statements that appear very early in the piece—the first paragraph or even the first sentence.

Works of literature, on the other hand, usually do not contain a specific sentence that sums up the core concept of the writing. However, readers should finish the piece with a good understanding of what the work was trying to convey. This is what's called an **implicit** thesis statement: the primary point of the reading is conveyed indirectly, in multiple locations throughout the work. (In literature, this is also referred to as the *theme* of the work.)

Academic writing sometimes relies on implicit thesis statements, as well.

This video offers excellent guidance in identifying the thesis statement of a work, no matter if it's explicit or implicit.



How to Identify the Thesis Statement
 the Ann Kennedy essay, article, whatever it
 highlight; just read.
 one or two sentences that summarize the
 article.

3. Look for something in the article, a sentence or two (even a paragraph), that says essentially the same thing as your summary.
 4. If your summary is accurate, you will (probably) have found the thesis statement.

Watch on  YouTube

Topic Sentences

We've learned that a thesis statement conveys the primary message of an entire piece of text. Now, let's look at the next level of important sentences in a piece of text: **topic sentences** in each paragraph.

A useful metaphor would be to think of the thesis statement of a text as a general: it controls all the major decisions of the writing. There is only one thesis statement in a text. Topic sentences, in this relationship, serve as captains: they organize and sub-divide the overall goals of a writing into individual components. Each paragraph will have a topic sentence.

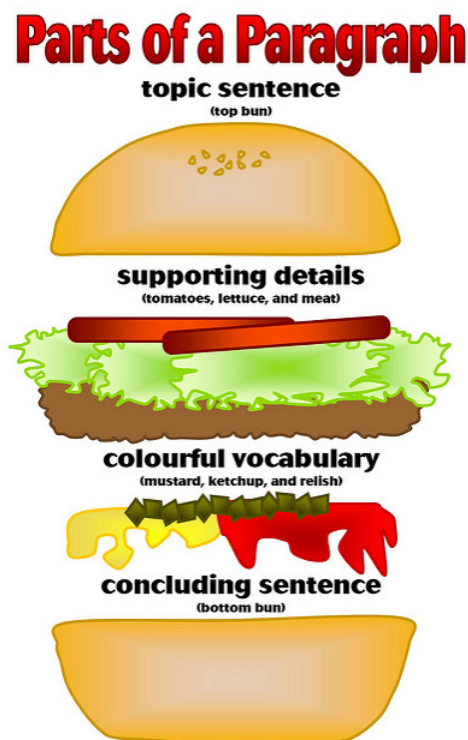


Figure 3.2

It might be helpful to think of a topic sentence as working in two directions simultaneously. It relates the paragraph to the essay's thesis, and thereby acts as a signpost for the argument of the paper as a whole, but it also defines the scope of the paragraph itself. For example, consider the following topic sentence:

Many characters in Lorraine Hansberry's play A Raisin in the Sun have one particular dream in which they are following, though the character Walter pursues his most

| *aggressively.*

If this sentence controls the paragraph that follows, then all sentences in the paragraph must relate in some way to Walter and the pursuit of his dream.

Topic sentences often act like tiny thesis statements. Like a thesis statement, a topic sentence makes a claim of some sort. As the thesis statement is the unifying force in the essay, so the topic sentence must be the unifying force in the paragraph. Further, as is the case with the thesis statement, when the topic sentence makes a claim, the paragraph which follows must expand, describe, or prove it in some way. Topic sentences make a point and give reasons or examples to support it.

The topic sentence is often, though not always, the first sentence of a paragraph.

Self-Check

1. Academic writing usually includes an explicit thesis statement.

- a. true.
- b. false.

2. What kind of thesis is likely if you have read the whole work, summarized it, looked for nearly matching sentences in the text you are reading, and haven't found a sentence or two that sum up the whole text, but the meaning and point is clear to you?

- a. A topic thesis.
- b. An explicit thesis.
- c. A detailed thesis.
- d. An implicit thesis.

3. Each paragraph contains a topic sentence.

- a. true.
- b. false.

Answer Key:

- 1. a
- 2. d
- 3. a

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3.1: Sacred Spaces (Reading Practice)



“Your sacred space is where you find yourself again and again” (Joseph Campbell)

We all live in a specific place on the planet, and where we live impacts, in visible and not so visible ways, the ways that we interact with the world, with other people, and with our internal self. The child raised in prairie or tundra spaces may find the deep forest intimidating or enclosing. The child from the seaside may long for water in ways that the desert dweller may not completely understand.

So the concept of Sacred Space will change from people to people, during history, dependent on location, belief and lifestyle. This unit will attempt to help us think about the concepts that make a space Sacred.

Let's start with a definition:

According to the Oxford English Dictionary, one of the definitions of the word sacred is:

“b. Dedicated, set apart, exclusively appropriated to some person or some special purpose.”

During the summer of 2010, PBS went on a quest to find sacred spaces in eight cities across America. The results of that journey is a curated selection which appears in their City Guides to Sacred Spaces in Atlanta, Boston, Chicago, New Orleans, New York, Portland, Santa Fe and San Francisco (downloadable at pbs.org/godinamerica/outreach). During this the staff thought long and hard about what it is that makes a space sacred.

Their definition of a sacred space includes the following:



Traditional Sacred Space – A house of worship designed and built for a congregation to gather, meet and enjoy community for the purposes of worship, liturgy and/or ritual



Civic Sites – engineered structures, secular in nature and scope – usually built by cities, state or government entities



Landscape Sites – sequestered spaces with natural features including water, trees, parkland which encourage quiet meditation and pause



Memorial Sites – markers of an event or person, burial grounds, cemeteries, sites of conscience and memory



Spiritual Places that have been imprinted over time, or have been historically seen as “sacred” a priori – set aside for the public good

Going Deeper...

Take some time to consider what you might have in the way of Sacred Spaces in your community. There are likely Traditional Sacred Spaces of some sort. What else can you think of that exists in your community that is a Sacred Space of some sort?

- **OPTIONAL:** Go visit a sacred space, one you have never visited before OR one that you are familiar with. Take a look at things like layout, façade, intent, function, and form in that space. Can you describe what happens in this space? Can you describe why it is considered “set aside”?
- **OPTIONAL:** For those of you who are interested in this topic, here is a more challenging reading related to Sacred Spaces. Though you are not required to read this article, this piece from Tricycle, a US Foundation centered on promoting Buddhist views, can help you to continue practicing active reading to increase comprehension and build vocabulary: [Sacred Spaces](#)

Religions of the world use varied places and settings for rituals, worship, burial, and other activities. Some of these spaces become more universal in use, as a church or synagogue or mosque might become, in many ways, a community center. AA might meet there, exercise groups gather, pre-schools find housing, clinics, tutoring centers, counseling centers –all of these may use a sacred space as well as the original congregation of people who built it. Some are much more restricted in their use. A monastery is not going to be open to the public, but lived in solely by the Buddhist monks or Catholic monks who dwell there. A labyrinth is limited in use to the walking of it–this is not a park, nor a playground.

Key Takeaway: Creating Sacred Space

Look at how the concept of Sacred and Space come together in this modern example from upstate New York: it’s a response to the Covid pandemic.

- [Pandemic grief and hope](#)

Places become sacred because of their use, their intent, their functions. As we look at various religions, we will be looking at various ways that religions uses particular kinds of spaces. We also will see, in news articles, in research, in social media and in reflections that you create, the ways that spaces become sacred and why they become sacred.

EXAMPLES

There are a vast diversity of Sacred Spaces. You might enjoy visiting some that may not have originally occurred to you as being set aside as somehow sacred:

- [Angkor Wat](#)
- [Brazilian Forest Reserve](#)
- [Mausoleum of the First Qin Emperor](#)
- [Okapi Wildlife Reserve](#)
- [Joya de Ceren Archeological site](#)
- [Taj Mahal](#)
- [Masada](#)
- [Auschwitz Birkenau](#)
- [Singapore Botanic Gardens](#)
- [Independence Hall](#)



“God In America.” *PBS*, Public Broadcasting Service, www.pbs.org/godinamerica/outreach/tour.html.

UNESCO, en.unesco.org/.

“The Buddhist Review – The Independent Voice of Buddhism in the West.” *Tricycle*, tricycle.org/.

Adams, Beth. “Earth Altars: Sacred Spaces Honor Pandemic Grief, Offer Hope for Future.” *WXXI News*, Public New New York, 2021, www.wxxinews.org/post/earth-altars-sacred-spaces-honor-pandemic-grief-offer-hope-future.

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4: Specialized Reading Strategies

Learning Objectives

- Identify strategies for reading on digital devices
- Identify strategies for reading math, social science, and science texts
- Identify strategies for reading graphics (charts, etc.)

New technology offers us many more exciting ways to interact with reading content, whether it's for work, school, or pleasure. It also changes the way that we understand what we read, when we move from printed pages to computer screens, as the following excerpt explains.

"HYPERLINKS"

Embedded [hyperlinks](#) in documents or Internet pages have been found to make different demands on the reader than traditional text. Some authors, such as [Nicholas Carr](#), contend that the internet may have a negative impact on attention and reading comprehension. Some studies report increased demands of reading hyperlinked text in terms of cognitive load, or the amount of information actively maintained in one's mind. One study showed that going from about 5 hyperlinks per page to about 11 per page reduced college students' understanding (assessed by multiple choice tests) of articles about alternative energy. This can be attributed to the decision-making process (deciding whether to click on it) required by each hyperlink, which may reduce comprehension of surrounding text.

On the other hand, other studies have shown that if a short summary of the link's content is provided when the mouse pointer hovers over it, then comprehension of the text is improved. "Navigation hints" about which links are most relevant improved comprehension. Finally, the background knowledge of the reader can partially determine the effect hyperlinks have on comprehension. In a study of reading comprehension with subjects who were familiar or unfamiliar with art history, texts which were hyperlinked to one another hierarchically (in order of importance) were easier for novices to understand than texts which were hyperlinked semantically (in order of relationships between content). In contrast, those already familiar with the topic understood the content equally well with both types of organization.

This section will address best practices to adopt when reading particular kinds of sources, like math textbooks and online content.



Figure 4.1

Online Reading Strategies

It's more and more likely that you'll have to do at least some of your reading for college online. Class readings, library resources, and even textbooks are going digital. Reading online is convenient, and often cheaper than accessing print versions. It can be quite a different experience to closely read and retain information from a screen, rather than a printed page, however.

You should practice some strategies that will improve your online reading comprehension and speed. And some of the tactics you learn about here will help you with any kind of reading you might do, not just the stuff that's online.

Print vs. Online

So what do we mean when we say that reading print is different from reading online?

- First, when you read something—let’s say, a book—that’s been printed by a reputable publishing house, you can assume that the work is authoritative. The author had to be vetted by a publishing house and multiple editors, right? But when you read something online, it might have been written or posted by anybody. This means that you have to seriously evaluate the authority of the information you’re reading. Pay attention to who was writing what you’re reading—can you identify the author? What are his or her credentials?
- Second, in the print world, texts may include pictures, graphics, or other visual elements to supplement the author’s writing. But in the digital realm, this supplementary material might also include hyperlinks, audio, and video, as well. This will fundamentally change the reading experience for you because online reading can be interactive in a way that a print book can’t. An online environment allows you to work and play with content rather than passively absorbing it.
- Finally, when you read in print, you generally read sequentially, from the first word to the last. Maybe you’ll flip to an index or refer to a footnote, but otherwise the way you read is fairly consistent and straightforward. Online, however, you can be led quickly into an entirely new area of reading by clicking on links or related content. Have you ever been studying for class and fall down a Wikipedia rabbit hole while looking for unfamiliar terms? You might have started by investigating the French Revolution, but half an hour later you find yourself reading about the experimental jazz scene in 1970s New York. You can’t really do that with a book.

Why, What, How?

Now that you’ve heard about how reading online differs from reading print, you should know that this has some really practical consequences for reading comprehension—how to understand and apply what you’re reading. Improving your online reading comprehension will save you time and frustration when you work on your assignments. You’ll be able to understand your course subject matter better, and your performance on your quizzes and exams will improve.

Why?	“Why am I being asked to read this passage?”	In other words, what are the instructions my professor has given me?
What?	“What am I supposed to get out of this passage?”	That is, what are the main concerns, questions, and points of the text? What do you need to remember for class?
How?	“How will I remember what I just read?”	In most cases, this means taking notes and defining key terms.

When you keep the “why, what and how” of reading comprehension in the forefront of your mind while reading, your understanding of the material will improve drastically. It will only take a few minutes, but it will not only help you remember what you’ve read, but also structure any notes that you might want to take.

Student Q & A

Let’s consider some questions about online reading, courtesy of students just like you. Consider what your own response to each of the following questions might be, then click “answer” to learn some more!



Question: I’m so used to reading printed texts, and I actually prefer it because I don’t get distracted as easily as I do when I’m online. So how can I keep myself from getting distracted when reading online?

Answer

When you read online, the hyperlinks, images, audio, and video interactivity embedded in the text can be a really tempting distraction. Try reading a passage straight through at least once without clicking on any of the hyperlinks or participating in any of the interactive opportunities. First, get a basic “feel” for the passage, then read it with the interactive components to augment your reading.



Question: I once had a teacher who didn't want us use our phones to read our assigned texts. Why did she care?

Answer

She's probably right—it's best not to read your assignments from the small screen of a smart phone. It's too easy to miss words and meanings when the reading process itself is challenging.



Question: You've talked a lot about comprehension, but I'd really like to know how I can improve my online reading speed. Got any tips?

Answer

So glad you asked! Reading quickly and efficiently will leave you more time to study, and improve your performance in your course.

To read more quickly and efficiently online, try most of all to avoid distractions like ads, pop-ups, or hyperlinks that will lead you away from your assignment. Another tactic you can try is to scan the page before actually reading, focusing on key words and phrases rather than every single word. It will not only help you to read faster, it'll also give you a sense of the text's main ideas.

How to Read Graphs

Line graphs and bar graphs are both visual ways of representing two or more data sets and their interrelation. In other words, graphs are pictures that show you how one thing changes in relation to another. Learning to read graphs properly is a matter of interpreting which pieces of information go together.

Steps for Reading Graphs

1. Identify what the graph represents. Most graphs will have a clearly labeled x-element, spaced along the graph's horizontal axis, and a clearly labeled y-element, spaced along the graph's vertical axis.

- The graph's title should also tell you exactly what it's about.

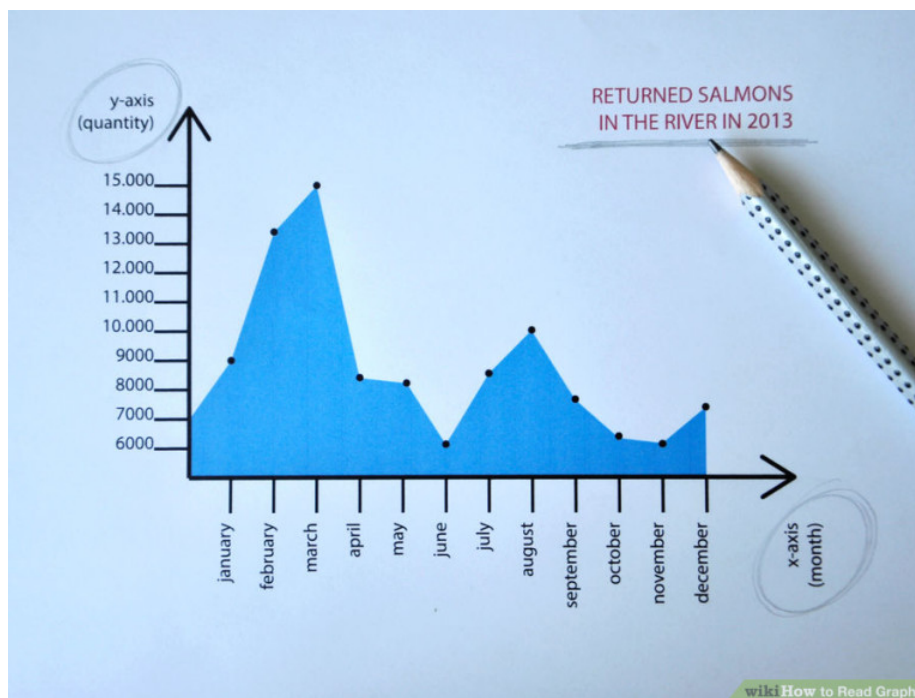


Figure 4.2

2. **Check the scale for each graph element.** This applies to both line graphs and bar graphs.

- For example, if you're looking at a graph that shows how many salmon returned to a given stream over the period of a few months last year, each increment along the graph's y-axis might represent hundreds, thousands or tens of thousands of salmon returning; you won't know which scale numbers apply until you check the graph.

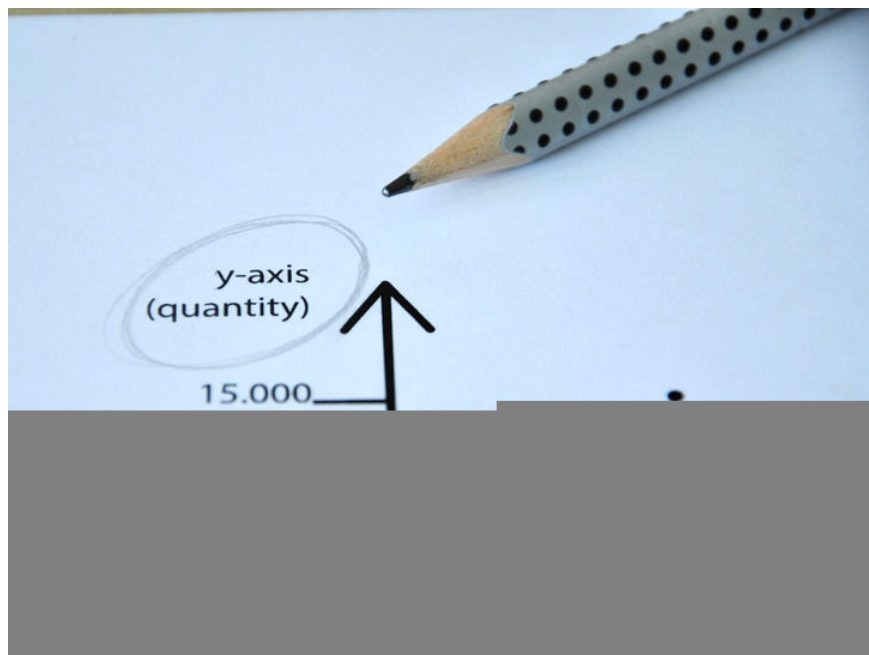


Figure 4.3

3. **Locate the graph element you want information on.**

- For example, you might want to know how many salmon returned to the stream in question in August of last year. So you'd read across the graph's horizontal axis until you find "August."

- Time elements, such as days, weeks, months or years, are almost always listed along the horizontal (“x”) axis. Quantity measurements are almost always listed along the vertical (“y”) axis.



Figure 4.4

4. Read directly up from “August” until you find a dot or a slanting line, on a line graph, or the top of a bar for a bar graph. Then read straight across to the left until you hit the graph’s labeled y-axis. Whatever quantity that line intersects with is the measurement for salmon return in August.

- So if you read up to the dot, line or top of the bar for salmon in August then read across to the left and hit “10,000,” you know 10,000 salmon returned in August. If you hit a point between any two labeled graph increments, you have to estimate based on where you land between the 2 increments. For example, if you hit a point halfway between 10,000 and 15,000, you can safely estimate that the correct number is about 12,500.



Figure 4.5

FINAL TIPS FOR READING GRAPHS

- Line graphs give you one piece of explicit information that bar graphs don't. The steepness of the line connecting each data point on the graph (that is, each dot) indicates the rate of change. A steeply descending line, for example, would show that salmon returns dropped abruptly from one month to the next. But a slowly ascending line represents a gradual increase.
- If the graph correlates more than two elements, the extra data sets are usually assigned to the x-, or horizontal axis. Often, the additional data sets are graphed in another color to avoid confusion. So if you want to compare the salmon returns over the same months for more than one year at a time, you could graph each year's return on the same graph, but in a different color.

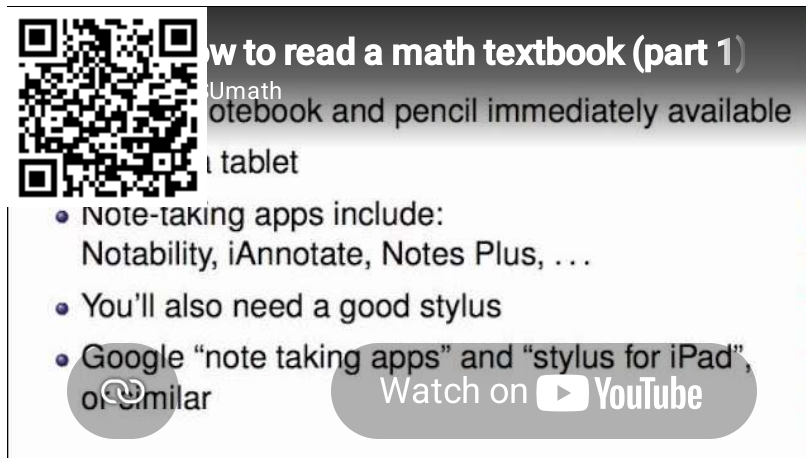
How to Read Textbooks

Similar academic reading strategies apply to all kinds of readings you'll do in college. Practicing the habits of **previewing**, **active reading**, **reviewing**, and **summarizing** will continue to help you learn, no matter the type of class you're reading for.

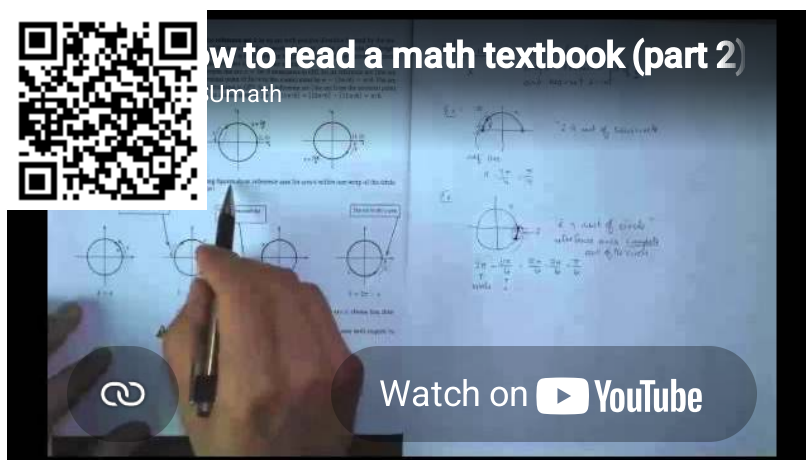
To take this advice even further, the following videos consider the specific needs for particular types of classes you're likely to take.

Math Texts

This overview video introduces some general concepts of how to read and study from math textbooks.

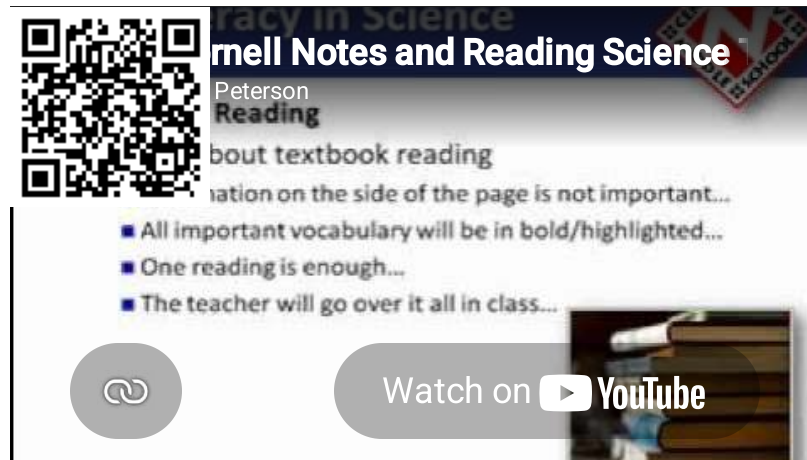


The second part of the series shows examples of concepts from the first video, as well as a summary of approaches useful when reading math.



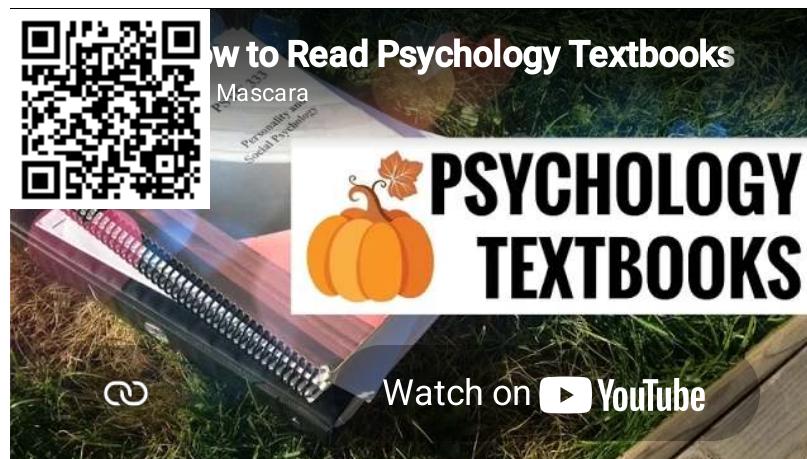
Science Texts

This video debunks myths students might believe about reading science textbooks. It also introduces a specific type of note-taking, called the Cornell Method, which is useful for other types of academic reading as well.



Social Science Texts

This video models reading a Psychology textbook. The same techniques will be useful with other social science books, including Sociology, History, and Anthropology. It includes nice tips regarding tables and graphs.



Self-Check

1. Embedded _____ in documents or internet pages have been found to make different demands on a reader than traditional text.
 - a. hyperlinks
 - b. images
 - c. headings
 - d. subheadings
2. How do I identify what a graph represents?
 - a. Identify the x-axis of a graph.
 - b. Identify the y-axis of a graph.
 - c. Read the graph's title.

d. All of the above.

3. The best way to read a science textbook in order to really learn from it would be which of the following of these choices?

- a. read the main text, highlight anything that might be important with a blue or yellow marker, write down the page numbers you might want to go back to, and ignore the sidebars because they are distracting.
- b. write down anything in bold, pay attention to the course lectures for clues to what the instructor thinks is important, and take down quotes that you think are important.
- c. pay attention to the sidebars, take notes on all words you don't know, read the chapter again if you need to, try the Cornell note-taking strategy, and don't assume only material covered in class will be on the test.
- d. Read the chapter through once, slowly, then write an outline.

Answer Key:

- 1. a
- 2. d
- 3. c

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5: Summarizing

Introduction

Are you familiar with the phrase, *the best way to learn something is to teach it to someone else*?

Writing a summary of a source is a very similar process to teaching someone the content—but in this case, the student you're teaching is yourself.

Summarizing—condensing someone else's ideas and putting it into your own shortened form—allows you to be sure that you've accurately captured the main idea of the text you're reading.

Summaries contain only the most important information—for a funny example, check out this [summary of the original Star Wars saga...](#)

How to Write Summary Statements

Use these processes to help you write summary statements:

- Underline important information and write key words in margin.
- Record ideas using a two-column note-taking system. Record questions you have about the text concepts in the left column and answers you find in the reading in the right column.
- Identify how concepts relate to each other.
- Add only what you consider to be the most important examples and details.

For retaining key ideas as you read, write a summary statement at the end of each paragraph or section. For capturing the major ideas of the entire work, write a summary paragraph (or more) that describes the entire text.

These summary statements will be very useful to draw from as you review your reading in preparation for tests or projects.

For longer, overall summary projects that capture an entire reading, consider these guidelines for writing a summary:

- **A summary should contain the main thesis of the text, restated in your own words.** (To do this, first find the thesis statement in the original text.)
- **A summary is written in your own words.** It contains few or no quotes.
- **A summary is always shorter than the original text, often about 1/3 as long as the original.** It is the ultimate fat-free writing. An article or paper may be summarized in a few sentences or a couple of paragraphs. A book may be summarized in an article or a short paper. A very large book may be summarized in a smaller book.
- **A summary should contain all the major points of the original text**, and should ignore most of the fine details, examples, illustrations or explanations.
- **The backbone of any summary is formed by crucial details** (key names, dates, events, words and numbers). A summary must never rely on vague generalities.
- If you quote anything from the original text, even an unusual word or a catchy phrase, **you need to put whatever you quote in quotation marks (" ")**.
- **A summary must contain only the ideas of the original text.** Do not insert any of your own opinions, interpretations, deductions or comments into a summary.

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6: Logic and Structure

Learning Objectives

- Identify patterns of logical organization in texts
- Identify basic features of rhetorical patterns (narrative, comparison, definition, etc.)
- Identify logical structures in argument
- Identify logical fallacies



Figure 6.1

Human beings love order, and we will try to impose order in almost every situation. That includes reading. Clearly, most reading relies on understanding words in the order they appear in a sentence. Even beyond that, we anticipate patterns and shapes that particular types of writing will take, and we build expectations based on the first few sentences that we read.

This section will help you understand what you can learn from a piece of reading based on the shape it takes, in addition to what the words themselves convey.

Rhetorical Modes

Since most of the reading (and writing!) you'll do throughout your college career falls into the “academic writing” category, this is a good point to slow down and examine the building blocks of academic writing more closely.

Rhetoric is the study of writing, so the basic types of academic writing are referred to as **rhetorical modes**. Let's look at 10 of the most common types.

1. Narration

The purpose of **narration** is to tell a story or relate an event. Narration is an especially useful tool for sequencing or putting details and information into some kind of logical order, usually chronological.

Literature uses narration heavily, but it also can be useful in academic writing for strong impact.

An academic essay about the impact of lead in the drinking water in Flint, Michigan, for instance, might include a narrative section that tells the story of one particular family that's been impacted. This will help illustrate the broader impacts on the community.

2. Description

The purpose of description is to re-create, invent, or visually present a person, place, event, or action so that the reader can picture that which is being described. It is heavily based on **sensory details**: what we experience through our five senses.

Description is very useful in writing of all types.

In our essay about lead in drinking water, sensory details such as the color of the lead-contaminated water coming out of the tap, or the taste of it when used for cooking, will be informative and help clarify the dangers to the community of Flint.

3. Example

In our discussion of rhetorical modes, we've been looking at examples with the lead in the water of Flint, Michigan. An **exemplification essay** (sometimes also called an **illustration essay**) extends this idea even further: it carries one or more examples into great detail, in order to show the details of a complex problem in a way that's easy for readers to understand. Paragraphs can also use the example pattern if they contain multiple examples to support a claim within a topic sentence.

Writing in detail about the drinking water crisis in Flint might be used to exemplify the political situation where a state governor appoints an emergency manager over a city, taking authority away from a mayor or a town council. On the surface, it seems like these two ideas aren't connected, so the extended example of the drinking water situation will help readers to understand the potential consequences of removing local leadership.

4. Definition

A **definition essay** takes the concept of "definition" more broadly, moving beyond a dictionary definition to examine a word or concept as we actually use and understand it. Paragraphs that use the definition structure often focus on defining a single concept.

If we use the term "drinking water crisis" to apply to the situation in Flint, Michigan, what does that actually mean? At what point does the term "crisis" apply? A definition essay would examine the various factors that shape a public crisis, such as the level of lead contamination in water determined to be dangerous, the costs of drinking water to citizens, the difficulty in accessing water in other ways, and the damage lead exposure can have to children.

5. Process Analysis

Analyzing a process can also be thought of as a "how-to" essay or paragraph. Technical writing includes a lot of process analysis, for instance. Academic writing can incorporate process analysis to show how an existing problem came to be, or how it might be solved, by following a clear series of steps.

Tracing the steps that led to the current drinking water problems in Flint would prove a useful exercise in a process analysis essay. Showing exactly what steps were taken, and in what order, would help illustrate for readers how similar situations could be avoided in other communities in the future.

6. Division/Classification

A **classification essay** takes one large concept, and divides it into individual pieces. A nice result from this type of writing is that it helps the reader to understand a complex topic by focusing on its smaller parts. This is particularly useful when an author has a unique way of dividing up the concepts, to provide new insight into the ways it might be viewed.

Part of the reason that the Flint drinking water issue has gotten so much attention, is that it's such a thorny issue with so many potential long-term effects. A classification approach to this topic could divide the overall concept of "crisis" into individual threads: the political implications, the public health implications, the financial implications, and the educational implications.

7. Comparison/Contrast

Comparison focuses on **similarities** between things, and contrast focuses on their **differences**. We innately make comparisons all the time, and they appear in many kinds of writings. The goal of comparison and contrast in academic essays may be to show that one item is superior to another, based on a set of evaluations included as part of the writing.

A path to deeper understanding of the Flint drinking water crisis would be to look at another community that has experienced something similar. Comparisons and contrasts might be made in how the situation arose in each location, how it was handled by public officials and private citizens, and how it was ultimately resolved.

8. Cause/Effect

If narration offers a sequence of events, cause/effect essays offer an explanation about why that sequence matters. Cause/effect writing is particularly powerful when the author can provide a cause/effect relationship that the reader wasn't expecting, and as a result see the situation in a new light.

We recognize that lead contamination in drinking water is a problem, but many readers may not know exactly why that is. Drawing a cause/effect relationship between lead exposure in childhood, and later learning disabilities and physical problems once these children grow up, would be helpful for understanding the long-term impacts possible from the current situation in Flint.

9. Problem/Solution

This type of academic writing has two equally important tasks: clearly identifying a problem, and then providing a logical, practical solution for that problem. Establishing that a particular situation IS a problem can sometimes be a challenge—many readers might assume that a given situation is “just the way it is,” for instance.

If the fact that the drinking water supply in Flint contains lead is the problem, then an academic problem/solution essay will establish WHY it's a problem. This might include noting the EPA guidelines for lead in the water supply, and what Flint's water testing results reveal. Then, this essay would need to establish a solution for the situation that would be both practical and feasible. The temporary solution many residents are using currently is to buy bottled water to drink, cook, and bathe with. A problem/solution essay on this subject will need to offer a more manageable long-term solution for these residents.

10. Argument & Persuasion

The purpose of argumentation (also called **persuasive writing**) is to prove the validity of a point of view, by presenting sound reasoning to thoroughly convince the reader. These assume that the reader is initially uninformed about the topic, or holds a viewpoint that differs from the author's. The author's goal is to bring the reader around to his or her way of thinking on the matter.

Many different people, organizations, and political groups have been blamed along the way for the water crisis in Flint. A persuasive paper looking at who's ultimately responsible would offer a definitive answer for which group or person deserves the bulk of the blame. It would also effectively address why this matters to the reader—why a reader should care about making sure that the guilty party is ultimately held responsible for their actions.

As the examples of the Flint, Michigan drinking water situation show, there is a lot of overlap between the different rhetorical modes. Many academic essays combine two or more different rhetorical modes in one finished product. This leads to a rich reading experience.

At the paragraph level, however, there is typically one dominant pattern of organization (rhetorical mode) present. This structure helps readers to understand how the text is organized, allowing readers to more easily grasp the main idea of each paragraph.

Logical Arguments

Anything you read that includes an attempt to persuade you to think a certain way is likely to include logical argument as part of that persuasion.

The text below introduces the idea of **premises** and **conclusions**. As you read, think about the relationship of premises and conclusions as they align with main ideas and supporting evidence.

Elements of an Argument

ARGUMENTATION VOCABULARY

Claim: a statement or opinion that people may disagree upon

Argument: a claim supported by premises

Premises: reasons that support a claim, thus supporting a particular argument

A **claim** is an assertion about the truth, existence, or value of something that can be debated. Claims are also called statements or propositions.

When supported by **premises**, a claim becomes an **argument**. For example:

- This class is easy.
- The Baltimore Ravens have the potential to make the NFL playoffs.
- Abortion before the point of fetus viability should be legal in all of the United States.

Each of the above are claims, but they only become arguments when the writer gives reasons WHY the above are true, logical statements (**premises**).

? Self-Check

Which of the following statements is an argument?

1. Vending machines stocked with soda or candy should be removed from all public schools.
2. *Star Wars* is the best movie ever.
3. We'd better leave now. If we don't, we might miss the last train and we'll be stuck here all night.

Answer

If you answered #3, then you are correct! The first and second statements are not arguments because they offer no support. The third statement is an argument because it offers support (premises) to support the claim.

As we have learned **thesis statement** in previous modules, we have come to know that term as the main idea. But in argumentation, the thesis contains the main claim of an argument that is supported by premises. It is the logical result of the relationship between the premises. Identifying the thesis is the first step in understanding the argument.

But how do you identify the thesis? Follow these steps:

1. Ask, "Is this statement the main point, or is it a premise given to support another statement in the argument?"
2. Look for indicator words that often precede main ideas, such as

Therefore	Thus	As a result	That's why	Consequently	So
This Means	This shows	It follows that	This suggests	Hence	Accordingly

? Self-Check

What is the main claim in each of the following arguments?

1. Abortion is wrong because all human life is sacred.
2. It's flu season and you work with kids, so you should get a flu shot.
3. We should believe that rocks exist because we are able to see them.
4. John will probably receive the next promotion since he's been here the longest.
5. We must reduce the amount of money we spend on space exploration. Right now, the enemy is launching massive military buildup, and we need additional money to purchase military equipment to help match the anticipated increase in the enemy's strength.
6. It's a beautiful day. We should go to the park. Besides, I need some exercise.
7. That movie has had horrible reviews. My sister saw it and said it was boring, and her friend spotted three mistakes. Pick a different movie. I am sure we can find something better.

Answer

1. Conclusion: Abortion is wrong.
2. Conclusion: You should get a flu shot.
3. Conclusion: Rocks exist.
4. Conclusion: John will receive the next promotion.
5. Conclusion: We must reduce amount of money we spend on space exploration.
6. Conclusion: We should go to the park.
7. Conclusion: We should pick a different movie.

A **premise** is a reason offered as support, or evidence, for a claim. It is often indicated by these words:

Because	For	As
Since	Inasmuch as	As shown by
Given that	As indicated by	The reason is that

Consider the following statement: Today's freshmen cannot write very well. Joe is a freshman, so he must be a poor writer. The premises and claim are identified as follows:

Premise	Today's freshmen cannot write very well
Premise	Joe is a freshman,
Claim	so he must be a poor writer.

Critical Thinking and Logical Fallacies

Many of the texts you'll read in college will rely heavily on logical arguments. Logic is highly valued as a way of persuading readers, since it can be confirmed to be true.

However, logic can be used badly. When you're reading, you'll want to be able to pick out bad logic as well as good logic. This video series helps us identify different types of "bad logic" in reading we might encounter.



The Man Who Was Made of Straw



Getting Personal



Additional Resource on Logic... (Optional)

[More on Logic](#) [↩](#)

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7: Inferences- Text + Experience

The basis of “inference” is “infer.” Use word parts to determine a general meaning of this word.

? Watch & Learn

First:

1. Watch the video [Learn Inferences using Movies and TV Clips](#). Note-taking is recommended. Upon watching, it would be a good idea to:
 - Make sure you can define what it means to inference.
 - Think about an inference you have made recently.

Next:

Even short texts often require or present opportunities for inferring. Read the story below about Paul and Alice. What inferences can you make about Paul and Alice's relationship? What details from the text support your inferences (or in other words, serve as evidence to show that your inferences are logical?).

Every day after work Paul took his muddy boots off on the steps of the front porch. Alice would have a fit if the boots made it so far as the welcome mat. He then took off his dusty overalls and threw them into a plastic garbage bag; Alice left a new garbage bag tied to the porch railing for him every morning. On his way in the house, he dropped the garbage bag off at the washing machine and went straight up the stairs to the shower as he was instructed. He would eat dinner with her after he was “presentable,” as Alice had often said.

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8: Figurative Language and Narration

Review These Terms.

These are definitions you should know when performing literary analysis at the introductory level.

Prose

Writing without rhyme or meter (as you may find in poetry). Prose writing is usually grouped into paragraphs. Most of the text you encounter when reading is written in prose form.

Denotation

The literal meaning of a word; the dictionary definition.

Connotation

The meanings a reader associates with a word based on the reader's own background and experiences. Connotations may be positive, negative, or neutral.

Metaphor

Language comparing two unlike things by implying they are similar in some way. Usually metaphors use forms of the verb "be," such as "is," "was," "am," "are," etc.

Simile

Language comparing two unlike things using the words "like" or "as." The difference between a simile and a metaphor is that similes MUST contain "like" or "as" in the comparison.

Repetition

The reoccurrence of words or phrases throughout a text to achieve a particular effect.

Personification

A type of metaphorical language where something non-human is given human attributes or actions: Ex—The leaves danced across the parking lot.

Imagery

Using language that appeals to the senses to create a descriptive picture for readers. Look for language that describes what something looks like, tastes like, smells like, feels like, sounds like in vivid detail.

Situational Irony

When we expect one thing, but get the exact opposite. For example, an airplane pilot afraid of heights.

Verbal Irony

Saying one thing but meaning another. Ex—Telling your roommate, "Nice job, genius!" if they failed a test.

Dramatic Irony

When the irony--that which is unexpected--occurs in the structure of a text, such as a play. In this type of irony, it is common for the audience/readers to realize information before a character does. For example, in the famous Greek tragedy *Oedipus Rex*, King Oedipus is looking for a murderer and making a big deal about finding and punishing the murderer. Little does he know, he IS the murderer he is looking for (fascinating story, look it up if you've never heard of it). Because the audience and multiple other characters realize that Oedipus is the killer that he seeks before good 'ole Oedipus figures it out, this is a classic example of dramatic irony.

Hyperbole

An extreme exaggeration. For example, "I'm so hungry, I could eat a whole elephant!"

Understatement

Saying much less than what is true. For example, an athlete who won Most Valuable Player after an absolutely amazing season might say something like, "I did alright."

Satire

A story, play, novel, film, or other work which uses the use of humor, irony, exaggeration, or ridicule to expose and criticize people's stupidity or vices, particularly in the context of contemporary politics and other topical issues.

Narration--the following terms relate to how a story is told.

Narrator

The character telling the story.

Unreliable narrator

A narrator who the reader cannot trust to tell the facts of the story accurately.

First-person narration

Narration told through the viewpoint of a single character who uses "I," "you," and "we." This character may or may not be involved in the events of the story.

Third-person limited narration

Narration told by a character outside of the story who does not refer to him- or herself as "I," "you," or "we." Yet, you do have access to this character's thoughts and feelings.

Third-person omniscient narration

Narration written by a character outside of the story who has access to all information in the story. This mode of narration does not use "I," "you," or "we," but you have access to multiple characters' inner thoughts and feelings.

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8.1: Literary Analysis Practice

Reading Exercise

Read the following short story linked [here](#), keeping in mind the terms you just learned from the previous OER reading.

Think About It

After reading the linked short story, you should be able to:

- Identify the narrative mode the story was relayed in, and give evidence to support your answer.
- Identify words with strong connotations, and think about why the author might have included those particular word choices.
- Describe the mood of the story.

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8.2: Symbols and Allusions

A symbol, as you may already know, is an item that represents something else beyond its literal meaning, often something abstract. Here are a few examples in different media:



- Barack Obama’s 2008 campaign logo: the O, of course, stands in for the candidate’s last name; the red lines seem to suggest a road (implying progress), or maybe waving American flag; the blue curve represents a clear, blue sky (implying safety or wellbeing); the colors themselves are perhaps symbolic of bipartisan cooperation, or at the very least, the American color palette of red, white, and blue.
- In Edgar Allan Poe’s “The Black Cat,” the titular black cat symbolizes the narrator’s descent into madness, alcoholism, and violence, and later his guilt for that descent.
- The teaspoon used to hypnotize people in the film *Get Out* (2017) symbolizes wealth, power, and privilege (a “silver spoon”), suggesting that those structures are tools for control and domination.

* A **motif** is closely related to a symbol, but it is different. A motif is a recurring image, word, or phrase that helps to carry a theme or other abstract idea. For example, William Faulkner’s short story “A Rose for Emily” includes frequent use of the word “dust.” While the dust is not necessarily symbolic of anything, it certainly brings to mind a variety of **connotations**: reading “dust” makes you think of time passing, stagnancy, decay, and so on. Therefore, the motif of “dust” helps contribute to bigger characteristics, like tone and themes.

Allusion: A literary allusion is a **reference** to something the writer expects the reader to understand--shared cultural knowledge. Allusions are connections a text makes to something beyond the text--types of allusions could include references to other texts, to history, to religion, to art, or to pop culture.

- C.S. Lewis’ classic young adult series, *The Chronicles of Narnia*, is a Christian allegory. The imagery used to describe the main hero, Aslan the lion, as well as a number of the other stories and details, parallel the New Testament. In turn, Aslan is imbued with the savior connotation of Jesus Christ.
- The TV show *Bob’s Burgers* makes frequent references to pop culture. For instance, the fictional boy band featured in the show, Boyz 4 Now, closely resembles One Direction, *NSYNC, and Backstreet Boys—and their name is clearly a reference to Boyz II Men.
- “Woman Hollering Creek,” a short story by Sandra Cisneros, deals with the dangers of interpersonal violence. The protagonist refers frequently to *telenovelas*, soap operas that set unrealistic and problematic assumptions for healthy relationships. These references suggest to us that interpersonal violence is pervasive in media and social norms.

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9: Tone

Tone identifies a speaker's attitude toward a subject or another person. You may pick up a person's tone of voice fairly easily in conversation. A friend who tells you about her weekend may speak excitedly about a fun skiing trip. An instructor who means business may speak in a low, slow voice to emphasize her serious mood. Or, a coworker who needs to let off some steam after a long meeting may crack a sarcastic joke.

Just as speakers transmit emotion through voice, writers can transmit through writing a range of attitudes, from excited and humorous to somber and critical. These emotions create connections among the audience, the author, and the subject, ultimately building a relationship between the audience and the text. To stimulate these connections, writers convey their attitudes and feelings with useful devices, such as sentence structure, word choice, punctuation, and formal or informal language. Keep in mind that the writer's attitude should always appropriately match the audience and the purpose.

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10: Facts, Opinion, Basic Fallacies

Always Question Facts

The term **fact** refers to information that can be verified or proven. While this might sound very straightforward, there is more to it. It is always a good idea to question the ‘facts’ people present to you.

Facts often include numbers in the form of data or statistics. Empirical studies, or research, might also be considered to be factual. However, all facts are not created equal.



Source

The source of the facts being presented matters.

For example, you may read an article on smoking. If the author uses a study funded by a tobacco company that says smoking is healthy for you, you may want to question the *validity* of those ‘facts.’ The tobacco company stands to benefit a great deal if everyone suddenly takes up smoking in order to improve their health. This actually happened in the 1950’s in the United States.

Take the time to find the source of facts. In today’s political scene, for example, organizations are formed for the express purpose of hiding the source of funding for political ads.

Watch political ads to see who is funding the ad. Research the organization and look to see who their donors are. This will tell you a great deal about the credibility of the facts they present.

Inclusion, Exclusion

When considering the validity of a text, you will want to consider not only the source of the information, but also something more subtle – what information did the author *include*, and what did the author *exclude*.

Have you ever heard a story told in such a way as to leave out key information in order to get a particular reaction? Excluding that key information is called **omission**.

Omission occurs when important information is not reported or is reported incompletely. We can think of omission as being news that should have been reported but is left out of the news we read, see and hear. When important news is omitted, we get a skewed or biased perspective.

Authors who ‘cherry-pick,’ or use facts selectively, should raise red flags for you as a thinker. At the very least, when you encounter this use or non-use of facts, you should look more deeply at the research on the subject.

Opinions Are like Noses – Everyone Has One

An **opinion** is a person's thoughts or feelings about a topic, and most everyone has opinions. Yet, just as not all facts are created equal, all opinions are also not created equal.

You may think that opinions are to be avoided in academic articles and academic writing. Quite the opposite is true. Opinions can be very valuable in academic work, but like use of fact, it is important to examine the opinion carefully.

Question Everything

The first question you will want to ask yourself is, "Why should I pay attention to this opinion?"

This question, like all good learning questions, will lead you to more questions, which will in turn help you to determine how much value to place on an opinion.

Here are some things you should consider when you are evaluating an opinion.

- Who is the source of the opinion?
- What do you know of their **world view**? (sometimes called "*point of view*.")
- Experience with the topic?
- Economic position in society?
- Gender?
- Geographic origin?
- Culture or social group?
- Life experiences?
- Whose opinions do THEY value?
- It is unlikely you will be able to determine all of these factors regarding an author's world view. Nonetheless, you can learn a great deal by reading the "About the author" description on the article if it is present, or you can do a general internet search on the author.
- If the article comes from a peer reviewed journal, you can generally assume it is pretty solid research. **Peer reviewed journals** are just what they sound like – academic journals in which the articles must pass a panel of peer reviewers who are responsible for making sure the content meets current research standards in the field in which it is conducted.

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10.1: Fact and Opinion in Reading

When you are reading or listening to information, evaluate the author's style as well as use of fact and opinion to determine how you should value this information.

Objectivity vs. Bias

Ideally, authors publish **objective** texts, leaving their emotions out of them. Keeping the writing too clinical, though, can alienate audiences, so with the exception of research articles, you rarely see work published that is entirely objective. Even dry research articles can have hidden biases because humans are imperfect beings, and authors are human. There are going to be flaws in logic, or sometimes facts may be inadvertently omitted. That is to be expected. When we identify information as being reported objectively, we mean that the author did a reasonable job of reporting the information unemotionally.

On the other end of the spectrum, is something that has a negative connotation – **bias**. We use the term **bias** to refer to an author who presents information in a way that is prejudiced and does not present differing opinions fairly, or at all.

In academic reading, and in daily life, it is important to have the ability to identify and evaluate information that is presented objectively or with bias.

? Analyzing a Text to Uncover Bias

Having trouble determining whether or not a text is biased? Try the following.

First, make sure you understand the text. Annotate as you read, looking up words and building background knowledge if necessary. Once you think you comprehend the text at a surface level, read again, annotating for the use of fact and opinion.

- Identify the author's use of fact and opinion, using color coding and/or "F" and "O" to identify facts and opinions in the piece.
- Look back at your marking/color coding. Did you mark mostly facts? Mostly opinions? A balance of both?
- Even if the text is heavy on facts, is it possible that there is other factual information that might have been purposefully excluded? Consider why or why not, and do some more reading of different texts if necessary. Ask yourself (and other sources, if necessary) if the author and/or publisher are known to embrace certain views and dismiss others.
- After you've done the above, you can probably reach an informed conclusion as to whether or not the text is objective, slightly to moderately biased, or extremely unfair.

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